

Barnsley FC Fan Advisory Group Meeting Minutes

Date of Meeting	16 th October 2024		
Location	Premier Lounge, Oakwell Stadium		
Time	6pm		
Meeting Objective(s)			
Attendance			
Present		Apologies	
John Bird - JB	Robin Harris - RH	Martin Wilson - MW	
Kelly Drury - KD	Dominic Wood - DW		
Steve Brain - SB	Claire Calton - CC		
Phil Hall - PH	Heather Linney - HL		
Andy Gaskell - AG			
Curtis Ledger - CL			
Paul Gallagher - PG			
Agenda, Discussions, Issues			
Topic / Discussion Notes			Discussion led by
1. Welcome			KD
KD welcomed everyone to the meeting.			
2. Previous minutes			ALL
The minutes of the last meeting will be agreed offline.			
3. Updates from previous meetings			KD
a. BFC Accounts			KD
JF will provide an interim financial update in the fan’s forum. Accounts are due out in 2025 and JF will provide further information at that time. PG proposed using a framework, similar to the one discussed by Kieran Maguire from The Price of Football, to simplify and explain the club’s financial situation, including who owns what percentage of Barnsley FC. PG will gather details for the next meeting.			
b. Man United coach subsidies			KD
KD requested BFC publicise the supporter’s subsidy paid for by BFC JB explained that the club subsidised regular supporters’ clubs by giving them £5 per person for each fan who travelled with them. However, how this subsidy has been managed varies across the different clubs. PG noted that most fans might not even be aware of this subsidy.			
c. Charlton Season Ticket offer			
The Charlton “bring a friend” ticket offer received overwhelming praise. JB shared that as of now, 522 free upgrades have been claimed by 16/10. Overwhelming feeling from all was that it was a great offer HL asked how the seating is being sorted out as a specific issue has been raised JB – 2 things happening, clubs offering 2 season ticket holders and also free upgrades for concessions tickets. The person is trying to upgrade a ticket rather than requesting new tickets. Guidance has been put out on the club website. The club did look to offer free food outside but were not able to put this in place so brought the offers inside. HL and PG requested confirmation that enough hot drinks and staffing resources would be available to successfully execute the offer. JB assured that arrangements are being made. The club is also exploring reconfiguring setups to better support the event.			
d. Tracking Initiatives (sub-discussion)			
HL suggested creating a mid-season and end-of-season summary of various initiatives, such as the coach subsidy and other Fan Advisory Board (FAB) suggestions. JB confirmed that he is already keeping track of these initiatives.			

e. Reporting Joint Initiatives (sub-discussion)	
DW proposed that BFC and FAB should jointly report these efforts twice a season to highlight the work being done. JB reminded everyone that the club is also required to report fan engagement efforts to the EFL at the end of the season, so this ties in perfectly.	
f. Sky deal - Financial and Attendance Concerns	
DW raised the question of whether the financial support from Sky is essential for the club and if Saturday evening games are actually working out in terms of attendance and atmosphere. PG followed up, asking for clear figures on how much better off the club is under the Sky Deal. He noted that Exeter City has suggested their club hasn't seen significant financial benefits from the agreement. JB explained that the financial uplift provided by the deal might be negated if supporters don't attend the games which are rescheduled. He emphasized that, while money is important, the atmosphere at games is equally critical, especially as it directly impacts fan engagement and loyalty.	
g. Sky deal - season Ticket Sales	
CL highlighted a pressing concern: how the disruption caused by the Sky Deal might negatively affect season ticket renewals for the following season. JB acknowledged this, sharing that fan comments reflecting this concern are already coming into the club.	
h. Sky Deal - Impact on Traveling Fans	
DW and PG discussed the challenges faced by fans who travel from further afield, such as the London Tykes. Previously, these fans had been accommodating of mid-week games, but there's now growing dissatisfaction due to increasing disruptions.	
f. Discussion on Kick-Off Time Adjustments for Midweek Games	JB
JB noted that EFL regulations allow fixtures to kick off between 7:00 PM and 8:05 PM. The question posed was whether adjusting the kick-off time, such as moving it to 7:15 PM, could help bring more fans to midweek games. Feedback from FAB members: PG: Shared that an earlier kick-off time (e.g., 7:15 PM) wouldn't make him more likely to bring his daughter to a game. In fact, the change could make it harder for him to attend personally, especially when traveling from York for work. DW: Raised concerns in general about distributing the 100 free tickets Rapid Response Telecom give away on a match day. DW and PG: Agreed that maintaining the 7:45 PM kick-off time is preferable. CL: Highlighted that Friday nights are different from Tuesdays in terms of suitability for children attending games. General Observations JB explained that the Rotherham games timing was non-negotiable. However, there's value in gathering fan feedback on earlier kick-off times for future matches. CL emphasized the need for better publicity if earlier kick-off times are introduced.	
4.FAB Meeting structure & IT Structure	KD

Mechanism for Raising Issues KD inquired if the current method for bringing issues to the Fan Advisory Board (FAB) is working effectively. RH mentioned that no feedback has been received via his email inbox so far. PG: Suggested that the FAB needs to raise its profile and visibility, particularly through social media platforms like TikTok, Snapchat, and Instagram. CL: Proposed that the FAB should have a physical presence in front of the reception area on match days to engage directly with fans. PG: Highlighted the need for a noticeable sign to grab people's attention. JB: Suggested leveraging the Ozone system as part of the engagement strategy.	
5. Comms	
Overview/ Website The BFC website requires further updates, including the addition of meeting minutes and an FAQ section. PG emphasized the importance of publishing all meetings on the website, as the current setup gives an impression of anonymity. PG suggested exploring the creation of a dedicated FAB website or subdomain, such as fab.barnsleyfc.co.uk, and it was agreed that PG would investigate this possibility. Issue and FAQ Management PG: Developed a form and a SharePoint issue tracker in collaboration with SB to triage and track issues. This allows even anecdotal submissions to be documented formally through the tracker. PG also created a FAQ tracker to internally manage FAQs before they are registered on the FAB page or website. There was a discussion about how this system would function: KD: Asked if an auto-reply could be sent to users submitting issues. KD: Questioned why a fan would use the form instead of email. PG agreed to set up a session to demonstrate how the tracker would work and address these concerns. Introductory Videos RH: Suggested creating introduction videos for the FAB page. PG: Stated the need to decide on the key messages for these videos and proposed forming a subgroup to manage this. It was agreed all members would provide ideas for introductory videos to SB in the first instance.	KD
6. Match Day Ticket Pricing	AG
JB: Match ticket for this season was set in January when deciding on the season ticket pricing for the 2024/25 season. Now reviewing based on Tuesday night attendances. There are more offers coming such as ST bring a friend for £10 against Wigan Athletic, family ticket prices against Leyton Orient and kids for a quid against Crawley Town.	
7. Flexi tickets for 24/25 season	KD
KD: Are flexi season tickets being considered JB: Yes and will be launched shortly.	
8. Promotions for NYD v Wrexham	AG
The group discussed the upcoming Wrexham game on New Year's Day (NYD) and the opportunity to capitalize on their popularity and media coverage, particularly given the attention from their high-profile ownership and documentary series.	

Feedback and Ideas AG: Suggested using the Wrexham media spotlight to promote tickets, possibly through a pricing promotion or special campaign. JB: Highlighted that the game is already categorized as a Category A fixture as festive fixtures tend to be but noted that games on either side of this date are family-focused events, such as “Kids for a Quid.” KD: Proposed marketing the town itself to Wrexham fans as part of the game experience (similarities with mining communities). AG: Suggested exploring a “Welcome to Oakwell” campaign to make the event more appealing. CL: Proposed creating something unique that could be featured in Wrexham’s documentary series, such as a playful theme like “Welshpool vs. Toby Tyke.” Next Steps AG: Agreed to contact the Wrexham Supporters Trust to discuss potential collaboration or involvement. ALL: Continued brainstorming potential promotional angles to make the game stand out and attract more attention.	
9. Ground Tours KD: Asked whether the £3 fee for ground tours should be donated to charity JB: Explained that the £3 fee originated from a season ticket benefit where a competition was held to win a tour. Additional spaces were sold at the nominal fee of £3 as a trial. The trial has been very successful so far and additional tours have been put on. PG: Highlighted that offering something for free often leads to a lack of perceived value, resulting in no-shows. A nominal fee, like £3, tends to encourage higher attendance and commitment.	PH
11. iFollow Updates Technical Issues KD: inquired about the resolution of the technical issues JB: Confirmed improvements but asked if the issues have been fully collated. CL: Mentioned that this process has begun. Pass Sales Statistics JB: Shared that seasonal passes are down this season, possibly due to the accessibility of the fixtures on Sky Sports +. FAB were asked for further feedback from supporters. Feedback on Commentary and Features PG: Mentioned that some fans have cancelled their subscriptions due to 1. Loss of Full match replays. 2. Radio service issues. Usability Issues PG: Suggested that full match replays need their own category on the website for easier navigation. He noted the removal of commentary from replays as another point of dissatisfaction.	KD
12. Saturday only Season Tickets KD: Suggested the idea of introducing a Saturday-only season ticket as a potential option for fans. JB: Responded that this concept doesn’t work for several reasons, citing other clubs unsuccessful attempts at implementing a similar option.	KD

JB mentioned that flexi-tickets could be a more viable solution to meet fan needs. The club is currently considering an option for 8-match or 5-match flexi-ticket to be introduced at soon, at the same time as half-season tickets.			
AOB			ALL
AB: Safety query that came in –asked for it be addressed by JF.			AB
CL: Egress of traffic from South Stand car park seems to be improved recently DW happy to hear this!			CL
PG: Stockport game - Catering offers are not being given even in the first ten minutes of service. Offer says it available for 30 minutes after turnstiles opening. Happening all season. This person wanted 3 soft drinks. This was in the East Stand Upper. Wanted to charge 10.50 rather than £9. Has to get the supervisor every time which holds up the queue.			PG
Safe standing JB: Safe standing proceeding. Further meeting with all parties 16/10 Accessible toilet upgrades JB: 3 accessible toilets are now Stoma friendly. Will gradually roll this out to the rest. PG: Should RADAR keys be on use on accessible toilets SB: Has been discussed. What if don't have one with them?			JB
Accessible Passports JB: Accessible passports have gone out to 13 people with hidden disabilities so the club can make reasonable adjustments. Mainly toilets. The fan can show stewards to allow them to get to the appropriate facilities.			JB
Memorial wreath JB: Asked for volunteers if someone would be able to lay a wreath on behalf of BFC. RH, DW and HL are available			JB
JB: Thankyou to all from the club			
Catering Mobile Ordering App			SB
SB: Any further update on the mobile ordering app? JB: Cameron and catering team are still looking into this.			
Thanks from FAB members to JB and JF			SB
SB: Thanks to Jon Flatman and John Bird on behalf of the group for all they've done in helping setting things up			
Close – 8.15pm			
Action Items			
Action		Responsible	Due Date
Speak to JF about financial standing of BFC update at the fans forum.		JB	ASAP
Find the financial framework discussed in The Price of Football that simplifies club finances for the average fan		PG	Next meeting
Session to show form/ Issue Tracker		PG	Teams meeting
Come up with ideas for videos and send them to John		ALL	Next meeting
Create website and demo to FAB		PG	ASAP
Safety query that was raised by a fan.		JF	ASAP
Double check catering offers raised with Cameron		JB	Next meeting
Next Meeting			
Date:	20.11.2024	Time:	6pm
		Location:	OAKWELL
Objective(s):			